

in passing and want to visit your Web site, they would naturally try `yourcompany.com` first. Of course, search engines will help, but this point could be important in the early days of your Web site before you get into the search indexes.

In addition to the `.com` extension, you should also consider registering the name in country level domains. For example, if you are a business based in India, the `.in` extension will communicate an intrinsic message to your web audience. It will declare that you are an Indian company present in India, so you are reachable by phone or physical address without too much difficulty. If your site is an e-commerce site, it would also give customers the much-needed assurance of the legality of your site.

Domain names are valuable. You will need to have at least two to three possible candidates for your Web site name, as there is a good likelihood that most of the obvious ones are already taken.

Also, you will need to protect your domain name. Once your site crosses a threshold of popularity you can become easy targets for me-too Web sites trying to ride on your success. Unscrupulous punters will attempt to lure your customers away with underhand tactics: say you've registered your site as `mysite.com` and `mysite.in`. These scam artists will register `mysite.org` and `mysite.net` and host mock Web sites that look exactly like yours. In many cases, customers will be tricked into parting with their money with nothing to show for it. The ill will, though, will be entirely directed towards you! Protecting your name by registering it under as many top-level and country-level domains as you possibly can is necessary to protect your online brand.

Having decided on the possible names for your Web site, the next step is to find a domain registrar. Many hosting companies include domain name registration as part of their hosting packages. It may seem simpler to use their service; however, it could become a potential bottleneck if you want to switch hosting companies later on. The administrator account for the domain regis-